The imperfect tense

- The imperfect tense is used to describe:
    - **What you were doing** *(I was eating)*
    - **What you normally did/used to do** *(I ate/I used to eat/I would eat)*
    - **What you had been doing/had done for some time**
      (I had been eating for…. I had eaten for…)

- This is an **easy** tense to form, provided you know the present tense…

- To form the imperfect tense of any verb (except *ÊTRE*), simply:
    - **Find the nous form of the present tense**
    - **Remove the –ONS ending** (nous choisiss~~ons~~, nous sav~~ons~~)
    - You are left with the "stem". **Add the personal ending to the stem**
      1. je CHOISISS – **ais**
      2. tu PARL – **ais**
      3. il/elle MANGE – **ait**
      4. nous SAV – i**ons**
      5. vous ACHET – i**ez**
      6. ils CONDUIS – **aient**

- **ÊTRE is the only exception.** The endings are regular, but the stem is:

    - **ÉT** – j'étais, nous étions, ils étaient etc

- Have a look back at how "DEPUIS" was used with the present tense in chapter three. If you use **"DEPUIS" with the imperfect tense** it tells you how long something HAD BEEN going on at a certain point in time:

    - *J'habitais à Paris depuis cinq ans quand j'ai décidé d'apprendre le français.*

The past tense in French

- It is essential that you understand the difference between the IMPERFECT TENSE and the PERFECT TENSE. You cannot rely on the English translation of the verb you need. You need to think about the meaning. Consider "*I drank*":

- For **one-off events in the past** – use the **PERFECT** – *Hier, j'ai bu un coca*.
- For **anything else** (repeated actions, descriptions etc) use the **IMPERFECT**. "*Quand j'étais plus jeune, je buvais un coca avant de me coucher*"

Indirect object pronouns: *I spoke to him, I gave to her*

- The list of OBJECT PRONOUNS to learn last week were called **DIRECT OBJECT PRONOUNS.** These were the object pronouns that are used with verbs that do not use a preposition: *faire qc/manger qc/ voir qn/ écouter qn etc.*

- The DIRECT OBJECT PRONOUNS are:

    - *me, te, le/la, nous, vous, les*

- This week we will learn another set of six **INDIRECT OBJECT PRONOUNS:**

    - *me, te, lui, nous, vous, leur*

- These pronouns are used with **NON REFLEXIVE VERBS that involve the preposition "*à*" to refer to people** "parler à qn, offrir à qn, donner à qn, écrire à qn, envoyer à qn" etc

- They go in the same place as DIRECT OBECT PRONOUNS, namely **before the conjugated verb or infinitive**.

    - *Je leur parle* *Elle me donne un cadeau*
    - *Elle veut me parler* *Il promis de lui donner un cadeau*.

- If you have **a mixture of DIRECT and INDIRECT OBJECT PRONOUNS**, the order is decided by the table below, which you should memorise:

    - *me, te, se, nous, vous*
      le, la, les
      lui, leur
      y
      en

- **Examples**:
    - *Il me les a donnés* (note the PDO)
      Elles vont vouloir nous les donner
      Je les leur ai donnés (note the PDO)
      Le leur avez-vous offert?
      Elles se sont vues et se sont parlé

- Notice in the last example above that the first reflexive verb agrees and the second one doesn't. This is because **the first "SE" is a PDO**, whereas the second one isn't. (*voir qn*, BUT *parler à qn*). Have a look back at chapter 7.

- We will learn more about "y" and "en" at a later date.